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Use of Irony as a Feminist Tool in Sarah Kay's "Unreliable"

Introduction

Throughout history, humankind has had a long tradition of using oral performance in order to connect with their audience and present ideas (Arnold 172). Within the 20th-21st century, this tradition of oral performance has connected with audiences through spoken word poetry, also referred to as performance poetry or slam poetry in popular culture. Slam poetry as a whole came into prominence through the poetry contests of Marc Kelly Smith in 1980. Based out of Chicago, Smith's hope was to bring passion back into poetry and focus poetry on matters that were important to everyday people. Building off of this dream, Smith would go on to popularize and standardize poetry competitions, also known as poetry slams, that would focus on these themes of speaking for everyday people and bringing passion back into poetry (Britannica 1).

The poet Sarah Kay steps into these conventions of spoken/slam poetry in her performances of spoken word poetry, which often talk about bringing passion for life into the mundane aspects of humanity and the relationships humanity forms with each other. Born in 1988 New York, Sarah Kay was brought up in a multicultural and multireligious household, which would impact the way she approaches humanity and the people around her (Kay 1). Kay graduated with a Masters of Art from Brown University and with an honorary doctorate in humane letters from Grimmel University. Kay has gained the majority of her popularity from

social media sites, and her poetry has millions of views across the different streaming platforms. She has published four books of poetry and is the co-founder of Project V.O.I.C.E, which strives to promote literacy and poetry education around the world (Project Voice 1).

In her spoken word poem “Unreliable”, Sarah Kay uses a stream of conscious narrative to explore how a woman views herself and ability to communicate. Kay engages the audience by presenting the poem as though she is having a conversation with the audience. She starts by telling the audience about how the speaker of the poem is an unreliable narrator and builds off of the ridiculous idea of how the audience inherently trusts her. However, after Kay states that the audience trusts her, she begins to build an argument around the reasons why the audience should not trust her: her inconsistency with truth, desire for attention, and hope to be better than she is. Kay ends by pointing out to the people around her that she can be both the trustworthy person the audience believes her to be and the unreliable narrator she knows that she is.

In this analysis, I will be building off the work of Marvin Herrick, who focused on the use of rhetoric in poetry and how it is constructed to affect the audience. I will also be building off of Bonnie Dow, professor at Vanderbilt University, who focused specifically on the rhetoric used in feminist criticism. I have used the works of the University of Texas - Austin professor Susan Somers-Willett’s essay on slam poetry in America to gain context and insight while approaching this analysis. Finally, I will be building off of the essays of both Anushree Joshi and Bronwen Low, both professors from McGill University - Montreal, who talk about the impact of slam/spoken word poetry currently and the importance of it in social media.

Throughout this analysis, I will be using the feminist criticism lens to analyze Sarah Kay’s “Unreliable”. I will specifically be focusing on the hegemonies about female identity that Kay employs to both successfully undermine and affirm her identity as a female. By using

traditional feminine hegemonies in a successful way and then framing it ironically through an unreliable narrator, Sarah Kay's "Unreliable" successfully promotes feminist themes and makes a space for female voices to be heard.

Analysis of Hegemonies

In this analysis, I will be focusing on the hegemonies that are aimed at explaining the worth of females. I will first look at the poetry through the lens of an imposter syndrome hegemony and focusing on how that affects Kay's "Unreliable". I will then analyze the speaker of the poem's relationship with men and how that both affirms and undermines traditional male-female hegemonies. Finally, I will be focusing on how the speaker of the poem needs constant validation and how that impacts her relationship with the people around her.

Imposter Syndrome:

In the Merriam Webster Dictionary, it defines imposter syndrome as "characterized by persistent doubt concerning one's abilities or accomplishments accompanied by the fear of being exposed as a fraud despite evidence of one's ongoing success" (Merriam Webster 1). The common hegemony and understanding about imposter syndrome is that it only affects successful females. If a woman is rising to success, she must inherently feel unqualified to be there or as though she is taking the spot that others deserve more than herself.

The speaker of the poem reflects this imposter syndrome hegemony when she mentions first and foremost that she is "an unreliable narrator". The speaker states this first in the poem to identify and place a feeling of uncertainty upon her words, all the while knowing that this is the speaker's chance to have her voice heard. The speaker then mentions that she would "never lie to

you, but I lie to me all the time”. At this moment, the speaker is showing that she does not feel qualified or capable to be there by undermining the value of what she is saying. The speaker’s success must be a delusion. The speaker goes on to mention that she is “not an optimist, but [she] plays one in the group chat” showing how the speaker feels the need to pretend to be someone else in order to fit in and be accepted within the group. The speaker finishes out by stating that she is “in the middle of her own dramatic universe, and it appalls [her]” showing that even when she has the spotlight, the speaker feels unworthy of the attention and does not know what to do with the attention. Through these statements, the speaker of the poem is constantly undermining her own worth and focusing on how other people deserve to be seen more than she does.

The use of these imposter syndrome statements within “Unreliable” is successful in promoting the hegemony that successful women must feel that they aren’t good enough to get where they are. As Sarah Kay is presenting the poem, it is also apparent through her body language and voice that she, a well-educated and celebrated woman, deeply connects with the speaker of the poem and helps the audience to feel the insecurity of the female speaker. It is also clear that the moments where the speaker expresses uncertainty in the poem affirm the values of the audience as they begin to interact with Kay during her performance. This all points to the imposter syndrome hegemony being successful in “Unreliable”.

Relationships With Men:

There are two main relationships with men that the speaker of the poem identifies. First, she mentions the relationship of her father with her mother. Second, she mentions the romantic relationships that she has had with men in the past. Both of these relationships successfully affirm hegemonies about male-female relationships and how those relationships impact women.

First, within the poem, the speaker stops her narrative about her abilities as a narrator to highlight the relationship her father and mother have. She shares this moment where her father runs back into the kitchen with mushrooms that he has collected to share with her mother, who is waiting in the kitchen. The speaker is off to the side as she watches this interaction between her parents, and she is not included in the story.

This moment between the speaker's father and mother further affirms the hegemony that men should be the main focus in a male-female relationship. Previous to this point in the poem, the speaker mentions wanting to have someone to give her attention and is then directly interrupted by this story about her father. While the poem is being performed at this point, Sarah Kay pauses and gets more animated and excited when talking about her father than when she was talking about her own needs to show how the male in the situation is getting the desired attention as opposed to the women in the story.

This hegemony of not being seen or appreciated by men is further brought into focus when the speaker of the poem talks about the romantic relationships that she has had with men. The speaker mentions not wanting a boyfriend but just wanting the attention of having one. This is mentioned in the poem right after the example with her father. It is intentionally left ambiguous if the speaker of the poem wants the romantic attention of a man or if she wants the attention that comes with being alongside a man. Here, the speaker is further successfully affirming the hegemony of women not being the main focus on heterosexual relationships.

Constant Validation:

Building off of the hegemonies of imposter syndrome and heterosexual romantic relationships, the speaker of the poem finishes her work by including phrases that point to her

needing constant validation for the work that she has done. This desire to have constant validation may be built off of the feeling of being unqualified to be here, like the imposter syndrome showed, or it may be built off of her desire for attention from the men in her life.

The speaker of the poem first emphasizes this point when she says, “I don’t know who I feel that I need absolution from, but I carry around a shiny report card anyway”. She goes on to further show this need for validation when she states, “When I call and you don’t pick up the phone, it feels like the world is falling apart around me”. The speaker of the poem finishes out by saying how she “has never amounted to anything” but goes on to state all the ways that she has amounted to something and achieved things in her life that are worth validating. This is done to prove that the speaker of the poem is worth something and needs to feel seen and validated for her efforts.

In this moment, the speaker of the poem is continuing to successfully validate the hegemony that women need validation to feel that they are worthwhile. Instead of showing that women can be capable and independent individuals, this successful hegemony places women in a place of emotional dependence on the people around them.

Conclusion

While Sarah Kay’s “Unreliable” ostensibly affirms feminist hegemonies, when looked at through the lens of an unreliable narrator, like the poem states at the beginning, the feminist hegemonies take on an ironic meaning. While Sarah Kay is vocally supporting hegemonies of an imposter syndrome, dependent relationships with men, and the need for constant validation, the tool of the unreliable narrator makes those hegemonies ironic and disrupt them. This unreliable

narrator tool then makes the audience question the validity of the speaker's statements that align with feminist hegemonies.

Sarah Kay uses the poem "Unreliable" to pave a way for the female voice to be heard. By stating feminine hegemonies in an ironic light, Kay makes both the hegemonies and the disruptions a place where women can feel heard. Whether or not the women identify with the hegemonies or the ironic disruptions, Sarah Kay's "Unreliable" is giving the women in the audience a stream of consciousness poem that may mirror their own. As stated in her mission purpose, in the poem "Unreliable", Sarah Kay is being a "champion of vulnerability" and meeting women wherever they are at (Project Voice 1).

In conclusion, Sarah Kay's "Unreliable" provides powerful insights both into the female stream of consciousness and into the hegemonies that surround women's inner thoughts as a whole. By exploring the hegemonies of the imposter syndrome, male-female relationships, and need for constant validation through an ironic light, Sarah Kay is showing how women can also feel worthy of the places they have won, have an equally balanced male-female relationship, and feel confident in themselves without constant validation. Her use of the ironic unreliable narrator is a powerful tool for feminist poetry as Kay explores the depth of human experience and the power of seeing multiple narratives.

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